viewed as a reductionist, myopically intent on the details and challenging the entire idea of ecology as a science controlled by laws.

Gleason appeared to be saying that there are no patterns in nature: it is all random. Worse still, he was accused by some of justifying exploitative farming, since his ideas seemed to imply that people need not worry too much about disturbing the balance of the natural environment—because there is no balance. Gleason's ideas were therefore forgotten in the enthusiasm for developing ecology as a science. He became so frustrated that he gave up ecology during the 1930s as holism became progressively supported by the idea of the interactive "ecosystem."

Nonetheless, as ecologists continued to study the world, they found more and more flaws in Clements's theory. In the 1950s, the work of American plant ecologists Robert H. Whittaker and John Curtis showed how impossible it was to identify communities as neat units of holistic theory, and that the real world was more nuanced and complex. When it comes to studying ecosystems in the field, Gleason's ideas seem to provide a better fit.

In the ensuing decades, while environmentalists continue to champion holistic ideas, ecologists have also increasingly incorporated Gleason's concepts into their work. He is now considered to be one of the most significant figures in 20th-century ecology.